

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

TUESDAY, MARCH 24, 2026

‘If somebody crosses me, I go after them, and they all know that now.’

GARY A. ROGERS, *Winter Hill resident facing eviction*

Battle line drawn in the housing crisis

Somerville eviction fight is heading to a rare jury trial

By Danny McDonald
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — For Gary A. Rogers, a Winter Hill resident facing eviction after his landlord nearly doubled his rent, there’s a lot to be said for the power of “no.”

For two years, Rogers, a 62-year-old who works at a biological research company in Cambridge, has refused to move out of his home. His one-bedroom attic apartment is part of a non-

descript, beige multiunit house on Sargent Avenue, an elbow-shaped road off Broadway in the heart of a changing neighborhood that was once synonymous with organized crime.

Amid an ongoing housing crunch, he is now on the cusp of a rarity in Massachusetts courts: fighting his eviction all the way to a jury trial.

Last fiscal year, more than 39,000 eviction cases were filed at various courts in the state. At

Massachusetts housing courts, only 5.6 percent of eviction cases go to a trial decided by either a judge or jury, according to fiscal 2025 state data. So in a city buffeted by gentrification, displacement, and increasing rents for years, obstinance has made Rogers something of a cult hero to some renters in Somerville fed up with soaring prices.

“If somebody crosses me, I go after them,” he said recently
EVICTIION, Page A10



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

Gary A. Rogers is fighting his eviction from a one-bedroom apartment in this house on Sargent Avenue in Somerville.

REMEMBERING A DAY OF INFAMY



STAN GROSSFELD/GLOBE STAFF

Freeman Johnson, one of the oldest survivors of the Pearl Harbor attacks, was saluted as he arrived for his 106th birthday celebration at the Barnstable Adult Community Center earlier this month. **B1.**

Making the most of mahjong’s moment

BETH TEITELL
COMMENTARY

Not long ago, Christine McLaughlin, a Duxbury mom, learned that another mom was opening a mahjong shop. “Who opens a *mahjong* shop?” she wondered. A few weeks later, she read about a local woman who started out giving lessons and had turned into a budding mahjong tycoon. Soon, she began hearing that people on the South Shore were spending \$400 or \$500 on mahjong tiles, and converting their kids’ playrooms into mahjong parlors.

The game got inside her, it took on an urgency, and McLaughlin, a retired attorney, found herself researching “how to play mahjong” and worrying that her friends had already formed groups.

“I can’t be left behind,” she thought.

It’s a story being told again and again, as if a silent call went out, heard mainly, but not exclusively, by women. A few years ago, or maybe last week, many had never thought about mahjong. But then someone in their book club started playing, or a neighbor needed a fourth, or they heard that Ann Michael Maye, the wife of the Patriots QB Drake Maye, plays, or they saw it in “Crazy Rich Asians,” and suddenly they’re going on
MAHJONG, Page A10

Fatal tarmac collision closes LaGuardia

2 pilots are killed when landing jet hits fire truck on runway

By Christopher Maag
NEW YORK TIMES

NEW YORK — “Stop, Truck 1, stop!”

The desperate call from an air traffic controller late Sunday night came seconds before the first fatal collision at LaGuardia Airport in exactly 34 years.

The call came too late.

Two pilots were killed and dozens were injured when an Air Can-

ada Express jet collided on a runway with a fire truck as it landed at LaGuardia Airport around 11:45 p.m. Sunday. The force of the crash ejected a flight attendant, who was tossed from the plane and landed on the runway still strapped to her seat.

The collision shut down one of the busiest airports in the region, exacerbating flight cancellations and delays across the country amid

a partial federal government shutdown.

The fire truck had been deployed to respond to an aborted takeoff by a United Airlines flight, Bryan Bedford, administrator of the Federal Aviation Administration, said at a news conference at LaGuardia on Monday afternoon.

Leaders of the National Transportation Safety Board were gathering
LAGUARDIA, Page A6



SETH WENIG/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Officials with the NTSB on Monday investigated the site where an Air Canada jet came to rest after colliding with a Port Authority fire truck at New York’s LaGuardia Airport on Sunday night.

Harvard now faces more scrutiny

Department of Education opens new investigations of admissions, antisemitism

By Hilary Burns and Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

After a period of relative calm, the Trump administration is ratcheting up its pressure campaign against Harvard University, using a “whole-of-government” approach to push the institution to bend to its will as prospective students eagerly await admissions decisions.

The US Department of Education’s Office for Civil Rights said Monday it has opened two new investigations into Harvard, about race-based preferences in admissions and ongoing antisemitism on the campus, after receiving recent complaints. (The department said it could not release information about who submitted the complaints.)

The new investigations come days after the Justice Department filed a fresh lawsuit against Harvard, saying faculty and leadership had “turned a blind eye to antisemitism and discrimination against Jews and Israelis” on campus. The DOJ’s civil rights division filed a separate lawsuit in February claiming Harvard has failed to turn over documents and data that the government says it needs to ensure the university is not giving race-based preferences in admissions.

“No one — not even Harvard — is above the law,” Secretary of Education Linda McMahon said in a statement Monday. “If Harvard continues to stonewall as we try to verify its basic compliance with antidiscrimination statutes, we will vigorously hold them to account to ensure students’ rights are protected.”

The Education Department’s announcement
HARVARD, Page A7

Suit accuses school of Ponzi scheme

Parent says Croft founder’s bonds were part of fraud

By John Hilliard
GLOBE STAFF

A Croft School parent who invested \$160,000 in the private, for-profit elementary school’s bond initiative has filed a lawsuit accusing founder Scott Given of running a Ponzi scheme.

The latest allegations of fraud at the troubled school come as hundreds of families mount a desperate effort to raise enough money to keep Croft’s doors open and continue paying its staff.

The lawsuit alleges that Croft was so in debt it was unable to pay parents the interest it owed them for the school bonds. To cover those costs, Given sold a second round of bonds.

Paul Crockett, the parent who filed the lawsuit Friday in Norfolk Superior Court, said that if he knew the school’s true financial situation, he would never have bought the bonds, according to his complaint.

“It is clear, and Given has in large part admitted, that Croft’s finances are not what they were represented to be,” Crockett’s lawsuit said.

Given’s actions were “in the style of a classic Ponzi scheme,” the lawsuit said.

Given did not immediately respond Monday to a request for comment. Last week, Given’s lawyers said in a statement he was cooperating with the school’s investigation and “has never used any school funds for his own personal benefit.”

Crockett’s attorney, Nicholas Rosenberg, declined to comment.

Since founding Croft in 2017, Given has marketed it as a more affordable option to pricier private elementary schools such as The Park School
CROFT SCHOOL, Page A7

On the bright path

Tuesday: Sunny, a bit warmer. High: 43-48. Low: 33-38.

Wednesday: Getting cloudy. High: 50-55. Low: 39-44.

Comics and Weather, **D5-6.** Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 309, NO. 83

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Conflicting signals from leaders on both sides left a murky picture of whether peace talks were underway in the Middle East, and what prospects there were for ending the war. **A3.**

A trial began for Kelsey Fitzsimmons, a former North An-

dover police officer who was shot by a colleague as he attempted to serve a restraining order against her. **B1.**

A hearing on a ballot initiative to repeal recreational cannabis sales brought supporters and foes to the State House. **D1.**

